écentic — Market Research Summary

Last updated: 2026-06-02

Market thesis

The agent commerce optimization layer is a venture-scale market emerging in 2026, structurally analogous to the SEO industry that grew up around Google between 2000 and 2010. The catalyst: every major payments network, hyperscaler, and AI model provider shipped commerce-capable agent infrastructure between April 2025 and February 2026.

Market size

We use a top-down sizing model with three layered numbers:

Layer

Size

Source / methodology

What this includes

TAM (Total Addressable Market)

€3–5 trillion

McKinsey, January 2026

Total value of agent-mediated commerce by 2030, globally

SAM (Serviceable Addressable Market)

€262 billion

Salesforce, January 2026

Agent-influenced retail sales already in market (2025 holiday season)

SOM (Serviceable Obtainable Market)

€300M+

Bottom-up from average per-store spend on AI tooling

Tooling spend by the subset of merchants who will both have agent traffic and pay for optimization

The SOM number is built bottom-up: ~150,000 mid-market and enterprise merchants globally will install agent-commerce optimization tools by 2028. At an average spend of ~€2,000/year per merchant on this category of tooling, that's €300M+ in addressable annual spend.

The TAM and SAM numbers are about the size of the market being shopped through; the SOM is the slice we can sell into.

Market timing — why now

Six events between April 2025 and February 2026 mark the inflection point:

Date

Event

Significance

April 2025

Mastercard unveils Agent Pay

First merchant framework for agent-initiated transactions

September 2025

OpenAI + Stripe launch the Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP). ChatGPT Shopping goes live

The model provider with the largest consumer reach ships native checkout

September 2025

Visa announces Trusted Agent Protocol (TAP), Carrefour named launch partner

The largest payment network commits a flagship enterprise partner

November 2025

Carrefour completes its first ChatGPT Shopping live rollout

Real-world enterprise deployment confirms protocol viability

February 2026

Google Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP) goes live as an open spec

The largest discovery surface in the world standardizes its protocol

Forecast 2028

25% of retail search will be agent-mediated (Gartner)

The trajectory hits the inflection point

The combined effect: by mid-2026, every major merchant has the rails available to accept agent-driven traffic, and a meaningful share of consumers have access to agent checkout. What's missing is the layer that makes merchants competitive within agent shopping decisions — which is écentic.

Competitive landscape

We classify the competitive landscape into four tiers.

Tier 1: Adjacent categories we're explicitly NOT

GEO (Generative Engine Optimization) tools — optimize for being mentioned in chatbot answers. Examples: Profound, Otterly, Athena. They serve a different buyer (content / SEO) and a different outcome (mentions, not carts).

Traditional SEO tools — Ahrefs, SEMrush, etc. Adjacent customer base but different optimization target.

Shopify-native AI features — Shopify's own generative product description tools. Complementary, not competitive; we tell the merchant *whether* the descriptions actually win against competitors when an agent reads them.

Tier 2: Direct overlap (early-stage)

We have identified a small number of early-stage companies positioning in adjacent territory:

AI commerce monitoring tools — show merchants whether they appear in chatbot answers. Closer to GEO than to écentic; they do not auto-publish or close the loop.

Agent traffic analytics — single-purpose tools that detect AI bots in traffic logs. Single-feature, no optimization workflow attached.

None of the directly-overlapping early-stage competitors known to us as of June 2026 simulate head-to-head purchase decisions across multiple AI models and auto-publish the fix. We are tracking the public landscape monthly; an updated competitor map is maintained in a separate document and updated quarterly.

Tier 3: Future enterprise consolidators (5+ years out)

Salesforce, Adobe, HubSpot, Klaviyo — large MarTech platforms that will eventually add an “agent commerce” module via build-vs-buy. We’re an attractive acquisition target for this category.

Tier 4: Platform companies

Shopify, BigCommerce, Stripe, Visa, Mastercard, OpenAI, Google. These companies are partners, not competitors. Each could in principle build a competing layer; in practice, none have done so as of June 2026, and several (Plug and Play, Visa) are actively considering distribution partnerships with us.

Differentiation — three things no competitor does

This is the moat language we use in the pitch deck and that holds up under scrutiny:

Active simulation. We stage real competitive buying sessions across GPT-4, Claude, Gemini, and Perplexity. We tell the merchant their actual agent win rate — not an estimate, not a sentiment score.

Closed-loop automation. We don’t suggest fixes. We write the fix (title, description, structured data, UCP profile) and publish it to the merchant’s store automatically.

First on UCP + ACP. We are the first tool that scores readiness across both Google’s UCP and OpenAI’s ACP. As these protocols solidify, that first-mover position becomes a defensible distribution advantage.

The deeper, harder-to-replicate moat is the proprietary corpus: every simulation we run becomes a data point linking listing content to agent behaviour to outcome. With 80 self-serve customers running daily simulations, we accumulate ~50,000 simulations per month within a few months of App Store launch. No competitor — not even a well-resourced one — can backfill that dataset.

Market risks and uncertainties

Risk

Mitigation

AI shopping adoption ramps slower than Gartner’s 25%-by-2028 forecast

Year-1 thesis works even at half the projected adoption rate; the SaaS price points are low enough to attract merchants who are merely “AI-curious”

One model provider (e.g., OpenAI) launches its own merchant-facing optimization tool

We position as model-agnostic; merchants do not want to be locked into a single provider's view of their store

Shopify launches a native agent-optimization feature

We anticipate this happening within 24 months. Our moat shifts to: (a) cross-platform reach (Woo, BigCommerce, Amazon), (b) the proprietary dataset Shopify cannot replicate. Plus, native Shopify features have historically created the demand for third-party deeper tools, not destroyed it (cf. Klaviyo vs. Shopify Email).

The protocols themselves (UCP, ACP, TAP) fragment or compete

Our work product (titles, descriptions, JSON-LD) is broadly portable. We absorb the protocol complexity on the merchant's behalf.

Privacy regulation tightens around AI training data

Reinforces our positioning — we have explicit no-training commitments from model providers and never use customer data for training.

Sources and reading list

McKinsey & Company, "The state of agentic commerce", January 2026

Salesforce, "Agentic commerce holiday season report", January 2026

Gartner, "Predicts 2026: Agent-mediated retail search", 2025

Adobe Analytics, Cyber Week 2025 AI traffic report

Visa Trusted Agent Protocol announcement, September 2025

OpenAI + Stripe Agentic Commerce Protocol announcement, September 2025

Google Universal Commerce Protocol open specification, February 2026

Mastercard Agent Pay framework announcement, April 2025

Internal documents that inform this summary: - docs/context/idea.md — full écentic product specification - docs/context/strategy.md — strategy and retention thinking - Pitch deck (Red Bull Basement Finals 2026 version) and one-pager